MUSIC PRODUCTION

OVERVIEW

Applying leadership and 21st century skills, participants produce an original musical piece that reflects the annual theme on the TSA website under *Themes & Problems*.

ELIGIBILITY

Three (3) teams or three (3) individuals per state may participate.

TIME LIMITS

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. All components (music piece URL and documentation PDF) must be finished, submitted, and accessible via the Internet by 11:59pm ET on a designated date mid-May.
B. Musical piece must be more than one (1) minute and less than three (3) minutes in length.
C. Any entry below the one (1) minute minimum or above the three (3) minute maximum will receive a rules violation of 20% (twenty percent).
D. Timing starts with the first sound and continues until the last sound ends.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Up to ten (10) minutes is alloted for the interview.

ATTIRE

TSA competition attire is required for this event.

PROCEDURE

PRE-CONFERENCE

A. Participants review the TSA Honor Statement for Competitive Events found in the General Rules.
B. Participants review the Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) found in the General Rules.
C. Participants access the annual theme on the TSA website under *Themes & Problems*.
D. Participants record their design process within a documentation portfolio.
E. Participants submit a URL to the audio file, in MP3 format, and a multi-page PDF of the required documentation by 11:59pm ET on a designated date in mid-May.
F. Submission information and deadline will be provided in January on the TSA website under *Competition Updates*.

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. Judges independently assess the entries using the following procedure:
    1. Judges score the Music Piece criteria to determine the top twenty-four (24) preliminary contestants, which will not be posted.
    2. Judges score the Documentation Portfolio criteria of those top twenty-four contestants to determine the top twelve (12) semifinalist teams.
B. A list of the twelve (12) semifinalists (in random order) will be posted on the first full day of the conference.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. No more than two (2) representatives from each semifinalist team report at the time and place stated in the conference program to sign up for an interview time.
B. A maximum of three (3) members may participate in the interview.
C. Semifinalists report at the assigned time and place for the interview.
D. The top ten (10) finalists are announced at the awards ceremony.

REGULATIONS AND REQUIREMENTS

Students will work to develop their leadership and 21st century skills in the process of preparing for and participating in this TSA competitive event. The development and application of those skills must be evident in their submission, demonstration, and/or communication pertaining to the entry.

PRE-CONFERENCE

A. Musical piece and required documentation must be accessible online for evaluation by the posted deadline.

B. Entries that require a software download or a request that access be granted will not be judged.

C. Entries received or changed after the deadline will not be judged.

D. Musical Piece:

1. The URL to the musical piece must point directly to the file and not require any permissions or installation of software for evaluation.
2. Lyrics may accompany the musical piece but are not required.
3. Musical piece must be greater than one (1) minute and less than three (3) minutes in length.
4. All musical pieces must be the original work of the team and must have been completed within the current school year.
5. Royalty-free sounds, loops, and samples (whether free or purchased from commercial libraries) may be incorporated into the musical piece. However, you must credit the original source of these elements in your portfolio and clearly identify them on your track list. You must also explain how you manipulated or arranged these elements to create a unique composition.
6. Portfolio must include a visual timeline derived directly from the project software. This should take the form of screenshots showing the Arrangement View or Multi-Track Session. The screenshots must clearly display track names, automation curves (if used), and the structure of the song from start to finish.
7. Where applicable, all ideas, sounds, and loops from other sources must be cited. If copyrighted material is used, proper written permission must be included (see the required Student Copyright Checklist in the documentation portfolio).

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. Documentation Portfolio:

1. Documentation portfolio should be complete, well written, and professional in organization and appearance.
2. Documentation materials (comprising a “portfolio”) are required and must be submitted as a multi-page PDF document with pages in this order:
   a. Title page with the title of the musical piece, the event title, the conference city and state, and the year; one (1) page
   b. Table of contents; pages as needed
   c. A self-evaluation explaining the creative and technical process, specifically addressing the Composition structure and Mixing decisions; one (1) page.
   d. Lyrics (optional); pages as needed
   e. DAW Project Screenshots: Legible screenshots of the project’s Arrangement View/Timeline from the Digital Audio Workstation. Images must show track names, waveforms/MIDI clips, and song structure.
   f. Sample Manipulation Log: A detailed list of all non-original audio sources. This must include the source of the audio and a description of how the sound was manipulated to fit the original composition; pages as needed.
   g. Production Inventory: A list of all hardware, software, and third-party plugins used in the creation of the piece; one (1) page
   h. List of references that includes sources for materials (non-copyrighted); pages as needed
   i. Student Copyright Checklist (see 2027 & 2028 Forms Appendix); one (1) page
   j. Resources and AI Reflection (see 2027 & 2028 Forms Appendix); maximum of four (4) pages

EVALUATION

PRELIMINARY ROUND

Tier 1

A. Musical piece

Tier 2

B. Documentation portfolio

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Interview

Refer to the official rating form for more information

GENERATIVE ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) is permitted for this event. Refer to the Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) for Competitive Events found in the General Rules and Regulations.

STEM INTEGRATION

This event aligns with the STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics) educational standards.

LEADERSHIP AND 21ST CENTURY SKILLS

This event provides opportunity for students to build and develop leadership and 21st century skills including but not limited to – Communication, Collaboration/Social Skills, Initiative, Problem Solving/Risk Taking, Critical Thinking, Perseverance/Grit, Creativity, Relationship Building/Teamwork, Dependability/Integrity, and Flexibility/Adaptability

CAREERS RELATED TO THIS EVENT

This competition has connections to one (1) or more of the careers below:

- Artist
- Audio designer or engineer
- Audio operator or technician
- Broadcast technician
- Music composer

Participant/Team ID# _____

MUSIC PRODUCTION

2027 & 2028 OFFICIAL RATING FORM

HIGH SCHOOL

Judges: Using minimal (1-4 points), adequate (5-8 points), or exemplary (9-10 points) performance levels as a guideline in the rating form, record the scores earned for the event criteria in the column spaces to the right. The X1 or X2 notation in the criteria column is a multiplier factor for determining the points earned. (Example: an "adequate" score of 7 for an X1 criterion = 7 points; an "adequate" score of 7 for an X2 criterion = 14 points.) A score of zero (0) is acceptable if the minimal performance for any criterion is not met.

Go/No Go Specifications

- Before judging the entry, ensure that the items below are present; indicate presence with a check mark in the box.
- If an item is missing, leave the box next to the item blank and place a check mark in the box labeled ENTRY NOT EVALUATED.
- If a check mark is placed in the ENTRY NOT EVALUATED box, the entry is not to be judged.

☐ TIER 1 – Musical piece was submitted and in MP3 format

☐ TIER 2 – PDF of the documentation portfolio was submitted

☐ ENTRY NOT EVALUATED

TIER 1 – MUSICAL PIECE (60 points)				Record scores in the column spaces below.
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Creativity and Uniqueness (X1)	Relies entirely on unedited stock loops or presets; melody or beat is generic or repetitive with no variation.	Includes some original elements (MIDI or Audio); stock loops are used but fit well together.	Highly original sound design; loops are manipulated (chopped, pitched, or stretched) rather than used raw; synthesis or original recording is evident and unique.	
Composition & Arrangement (X2)	Piece lacks structure; it feels like a repetitive loop with no variation; transitions between sections are abrupt, jarring, or non-existent.	Piece has a clear beginning, middle, and end; transitions between sections are present but may be simple (e.g., fade outs).	Arrangement is professional and dynamic; transitions are seamless (using fills, risers, or drops); song evolves with distinct sections (e.g., Verse/Chorus) that maintain listener interest.	
Mixing & Audio Quality (X2)	Audio levels are unbalanced (some tracks too loud/quiet); frequent clipping, distortion, or muddiness makes the track difficult to listen to.	Mix is clean with no distortion; volume levels are generally balanced; instruments can be heard clearly.	Mix is "radio-ready" with excellent clarity; frequency balance is achieved (e.g. bass doesn't overpower); stereo panning is used effectively to create space/width.	
Appropriateness (X1)	Musical piece does not incorporate the theme well or at all.	Piece fits generally represents the given theme.	Musical piece is an excellent example to represent the given theme.	
			TIER 1 – MUSICAL PIECE SUBTOTAL (60 points)	

Rules violations (a deduction of 20% of the total possible points for the above sections) must be initialed by the judge, coordinator, and manager of the event. Record the deduction in the space to the right.

Indicate the rule violated: _____

TIER 1 – SUBTOTAL (60 points)

TIME DEDUCTIONS		
There will be a five (5) point deduction for each fifteen (15) seconds under the minimum time or each fifteen (15) seconds over the maximum time allowed for the visualization. The musical piece must be more than one (1) minute and less than three (3) minutes in length.		
Length of Piece		
TOTAL TIME DEDUCTION		

TIER 2 – DOCUMENTATION PORTFOLIO (50 points)				Record scores in the column spaces below.
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Portfolio Components (X1)	Portfolio is unorganized, unprofessional in appearance, and/or missing three (3) or more required components.	Portfolio is adequately organized; most components are present, though formatting may be inconsistent.	All components are included and professionally formatted; organization is logical, making the technical documentation easy to navigate.	
Technical Reflection (X1)	Self-evaluation is vague, brief, or non-technical	Reflection describes the general process and tools used but lacks depth regarding specific technical decisions.	Reflection provides a detailed technical justification for choices made in composition, mixing, and sound design, demonstrating deep understanding of music production processes.	
Engineering Evidence (X2)	Digital Audio Workstation (DAW) screenshots are missing, illegible, or hand-drawn; Sample Manipulation Log is missing or lists sources without explaining how they were manipulated.	Digital Audio Workstation (DAW) screenshots are present but may lack detail (e.g., no automation visible); Sample Manipulation Log lists sources but offers limited detail on how the sounds were altered.	Digital Audio Workstation (DAW) screenshots are legible and clearly show track names, waveforms, and automation lanes; Sample Manipulation Log provides specific technical details on how every external sound was manipulated.	
Resources and AI Reflection (X1)	Form is incomplete or vague and does not clearly explain whether or how AI was used, showing little connection to the submission or understanding of effectiveness and ethics.	Form is complete and clearly explains AI use or the lack thereof with connections to the submission or theme/topic (when applicable), addressing effectiveness and ethical considerations with adequate analysis.	Form is complete, concise, and specific, critically evaluating how AI or non-AI tools shaped decisions and outcomes, with strong alignment to the submission or theme/topic (when applicable) and ethical reasoning.	
			TIER 2 – DOCUMENTATION PORTFOLIO SUBTOTAL (50 points)	

Rules violations (a deduction of 20% of the total possible points for the above sections) must be initialed by the judge, coordinator, and manager of the event. Record the deduction in the space to the right.

Indicate the rule violated: _____

PRELIMINARY SUBTOTAL (110 points)

SEMIFINAL INTERVIEW (30 points)				Record scores in the column spaces below.
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Knowledge (X1)	Answers lack technical depth; students cannot use or define basic music production terms or explain the software tools used.	Students demonstrate a working knowledge of both music production terminology and/or the software required for music production.	Student(s) demonstrate mastery of audio engineering; they use precise industry terminology to explain their production choices accurately and can explain how music production software works in detail.	
Design Rationale (X1)	Students offer vague or circular reasoning for their choices; no specific technical challenges or intentional design decisions are identified.	Students explain the general reasoning behind their creative choices; they can identify at least one challenge faced during production and describe the solution they implemented.	Student(s) articulate a clear technical justification for their production decisions; they clearly describe the problem-solving process that led to the final design.	
Articulation and Delivery (X1)	Responses are mumbled, confusing, or lack confidence; students struggle to advocate for their work; posture, gestures, and/or lack of eye contact diminish the delivery.	Students speak clearly and respectfully; they can answer questions directly without significant confusion; posture, gestures, and eye contact result in an acceptable delivery.	Students speak clearly and respectfully; they can answer questions directly without confusion, posture, gestures, and eye contact result in a polished, natural and effective delivery.	
			SEMIFINAL INTERVIEW SUBTOTAL (30 points)	

Rules violations (a deduction of 20% of the total possible points for the above sections) must be initialed by the judge, coordinator, and manager of the event. Record the deduction in the space to the right. Indicate the rule violated: _____	
SEMIFINAL SUBTOTAL (30 points)	
To arrive at the TOTAL score, add any subtotals and subtract rules violation points, as necessary. **TOTAL** (140 points)	

Comments:

I certify these results to be true and accurate to the best of my knowledge.

JUDGE

Printed name: _____ Signature: _____

MUSIC PRODUCTION EVENT COORDINATOR INSTRUCTIONS

PERSONNEL

A. Event coordinator

B. Judges:

1. Preliminary round, two (2) for each forty (40) entries
2. Semifinal round, two (2)

MATERIALS

A. Coordinator's packet, containing:

1. Event guidelines, one (1) copy for the coordinator and for each judge
2. TSA Event Coordinator Report

B. One (1) stopwatch per group of judges

C. Interview questions

D. Tables and chairs for judges

RESPONSIBILITIES

PRE-CONFERENCE/PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. National TSA will collect entries until 11:59pm ET on a designated date in mid-May. The submissions are shared with the CRC manager, event coordinator, and assigned judges.

B. Review entries as they are submitted to the designated online storage utility.

C. Manage communication and Pre-conference evaluation (at least two [2] or more judges should be recruited earlier in the year). Coordinate with National TSA and/or the Judge Manager.

AT THE CONFERENCE

A. Attend the mandatory coordinator's meeting at the designated time and location.

B. Report to the CRC room and check the contents of the coordinator's packet.

C. Review the event guidelines and check to see that enough personnel have been scheduled.

D. Inspect the area(s) in which the event is being held for appropriate set-up, including room size, chairs, tables, outlets, etc. Notify the event manager of any potential problems.

E. At least one (1) hour before the event is set to begin, meet with judges/assistants to review time limits, procedures, regulations, evaluation, and all other details related to the event. If questions arise that cannot be answered, speak to the event manager before the event begins.

F. Ensure the judges have access to the online judging system.

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. On the first full day of competition, post a list of the twelve (12) semifinalists in random order.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Semifinalists report at the time and place stated in the conference program to sign up for an interview time.

B. Semifinalists report at the time and place stated in the conference program for the interview.

C. Manage the interviews.

D. Discuss rule violations (e.g. 20% deduction, disqualification) and have all relevant parties initial the rating form.

E. If necessary, manage security and the removal of materials from the event area.